G2 New shipping routes and geopolitical conflict at sea

Theme 1 — Maritime Areas and Geopolitics at the Heart of a Globalised World

Objective. Weigh the benefits and constraints of the new Arctic routes, and explain why maritime areas are a source of geopolitical tension — and sometimes of cooperation.

Dates to know



The big picture

The melting of the Arctic ice opens new routes — the Northern Sea Route along Russia, the Northwest Passage through Canada, one day the Transpolar Route — that promise shorter journeys and huge resources, but remain cold, costly, risky and contested; they turn a region of cooperation into one of competition between Russia, China and the USA, down to the race for icebreakers and Greenland. Further south, the South China Sea shows how maritime areas become conflict zones: China's nine-dash line against the claims of its neighbours and the 2016 ruling, artificial islands and maritime militia, and a dispute that has become global. Behind it all lies sea power, still dominated by the United States and its bases, but challenged by China.

KEY ISSUES

- How far do you agree that the geostrategic importance of maritime areas is a source of international conflict, rather than cooperation?
- How far do you agree that the benefits of the emergence of new maritime routes in the Arctic far outweigh the constraints.
- Examine the reasons for geopolitical tension over maritime areas you have studied.

KEY TERMS

The Arctic · Maritime Power

Summary diagram — Maritime areas: a source of conflict or of cooperation?

	Stakes	Sources of tension	Cooperation or settlement
The Arctic	Shorter routes, ores and fuels, development of remote regions	Sovereignty, crime, militarisation; icebreakers; Greenland	Long a region of cooperation and low tensions
Northwest Passage	A short cut instead of the Panama Canal	Canada claims it as Canadian waters	Benefits on paper, constraints in reality (DBQ)
South China Sea	Trade, fish, oil and gas, approaches to China	Nine-dash line, artificial islands, militia (2021)	2016 ruling ignored; the Quad and a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific"
Eastern Mediterranean	Gas fields (Karish, Qana)	Israel and Lebanon, technically at war	2022 agreement on the maritime border

Summary map — The Arctic shipping routes opened by the melting ice



1. Three routes: the Northern Sea Route (along Russia), the Northwest Passage (Canadian archipelago), the Transpolar Sea Route (future).
2. Open only a short time in late summer; expensive icebreakers: Russia at least 50, China 4, Denmark none since 2010.
3. Canada claims the Northwest Passage as Canadian waters; Greenland lies on its route.

Azimuthal polar projection, Natural Earth; routes simplified.

Map — Territorial claims in the South China Sea



1. China's nine-dash line (approximate) against the claims of Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan.
2. Paracels, Spratlys (Fiery Cross, artificial and militarised), Scarborough Shoal; the 2016 ruling in favour of the Philippines.
3. About 3 million km², more than US$5 trillion of trade a year; five maritime entries lead into it.

Mercator projection, Natural Earth; the nine-dash line is approximate.

Map — American sea power: the US Navy's forward deployed bases



American sea power: US Navy forward deployed bases

US Navy forward deployed base

Source: Council on Foreign Relations (IISS, US Department of Defense)

1. US Navy: 11 aircraft carriers, 66 submarines, 73 destroyers, 340,000 active personnel.
2. Navies by tonnage: USA 3.4 million t, far ahead of Russia, China, Japan, the UK and France.

Bases from the course's map; Natural Earth base map.

III.1 The emergence of new shipping routes: the Arctic, the future of seaborne trade?

The Arctic: three routes opened by global warming

The Arctic is the polar region of the Earth that surrounds the North Pole; its snow and ice cover varies with the seasons (key term). Global warming is melting the sea ice and opening new shipping routes, which represent significant challenges and opportunities for the international community. Three routes cross the Arctic: the Northeast Passage (the Northern Sea Route, along Russia), the Northwest Passage (through the Canadian Arctic archipelago) and the Transpolar Sea Route (across the pole, still in the future).

> **EXAMPLE** As the ice diminishes, a region once considered impassable attracts renewed interest: states want the new lanes for shorter transit times, resource extraction, military activity, regional shipping, fishing and tourism (Worksheet 9, Gabriella Gricius, 2021).

The benefits: shorter routes, resources and the development of remote regions

Arctic routes are a major short cut between Europe, Asia and North America, of great commercial interest, especially for China. The region holds massive reserves of ores and fuels, whose development would boost the growth of the neighbouring countries (Canada, Russia, Norway, the USA). New ports, jobs and cities could develop poor and remote regions and put them at the centre of attention.

> **EXAMPLE** The Northwest Passage could slash shipping times between Europe and Asia by thousands of miles, or as much as two weeks: one of the main reasons Donald Trump took such an interest in Greenland (The Guardian, January 2025, Worksheet 10).

The constraints: ice, cold, costs and the lack of infrastructure

The Arctic still has many obstacles: unpredictable seas, a severe climate, high costs and a lack of infrastructure. The routes are only open for a short period in late summer, and expensive icebreakers must clear the way for other ships. Along the Northwest Passage there are no big markets and no ports of call to refuel or repair.

> **EXAMPLE** "Come up here and see what you are actually dealing with": for Niels Clemensen, head of Royal Arctic Line, Greenland's only shipping company, the island has no big road network and no trains, so everything travels by sea or air — "it's going to cost a lot of money". For Johanna Ikävalko (Arctic Centre), the Northwest Passage remains "a very risky area for navigating" (Worksheet 10).

From cooperation to competition: sovereignty, crime and militarisation

The Arctic was traditionally a region of cooperation and low tensions; it is increasingly seen as an area of geopolitical competition between the USA, China and Russia. Three concerns: sovereignty (it is unclear who decides who may pass through the new routes, and under what standards); transnational crime (unknown ships may bring illegal fishing or trafficking), which pushes Arctic states, especially Canada and Russia, to control their northern borders, and so to more military presence; and the Russia–China relationship.

> **EXAMPLE** On the Northern Sea Route, China provides funding and technology, Russia provides access: a potential alliance that worries the USA, which may build up its military strength in the Arctic "just in case" (Worksheet 9, Gricius, 2021).

Icebreakers and Greenland: the new front of power

Owning icebreakers commands access to everything in the Arctic, from shipping routes to search and rescue and minerals: they have become a new front in the competition between the great powers. Russia dominates, with a network of ports and military bases. Greenland, on the route of the Northwest Passage, has become a target.

> **EXAMPLE** Russia has at least 50 icebreakers, at least 13 of which can operate in the Arctic and seven of which are nuclear, and military bases near Murmansk; China has four suited to the Arctic; Denmark, responsible for Greenland's defence, has none since 2010. Trump has not ruled out using military force to get Greenland (The Guardian, 30 January 2025). Course video: "Du détroit de Béring à l'Arctique : les ambitions russes" (12 min, January 2025).

A fragile environment and indigenous communities at risk

The opening of the Arctic has potentially irreversible environmental impacts. More carbon emissions in the polar region could accelerate the melting of the sea ice — or stop it: the effects of climate change are unpredictable. The fragile polar ecosystem and indigenous communities could suffer serious disruption, and an oil spill in the ice would be a huge risk.

> **EXAMPLE** Vittus Qujaukitsoq, head of Greenland's association of professional fishers and hunters: icebreakers would help some small fishing boats out to sea, but others think they "would ruin their way of living"; the melting ice and unpredictable weather already affect hunting and fishing in Greenland's rural communities (Worksheet 10).

III.2 The example of the Northwest Passage

The Northwest Passage: a short cut between the Atlantic and the Pacific, claimed by Canada

The Northwest Passage (NWP) is one of the shipping routes between the Atlantic and Pacific oceans through the Arctic Ocean, along the northern coast of North America, through the Canadian Arctic archipelago — instead of the traditional passage through the Panama Canal. The growth of its traffic is already a reality, because the extent of sea ice is diminishing. Its status is disputed: the Canadian government maintains that the NWP is part of Canadian waters.

EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE Greenland, on the route of the passage, is likely to play an important role in its future; the United States contests Canada's position and sees the passage as an international strait. (US position added from outside the course.)

The DBQ answer: benefits on paper, constraints in reality

M. Ros's correction of the DBQ "The benefits of the emergence of new maritime routes in the Arctic far outweigh the constraints" weighs both sides. For: a major short cut for seaborne trade (90% of world trade), of commercial interest especially for China; development of poor, remote regions; massive ore and fuel reserves. Against: no big markets and no ports of call on the NWP; contested sovereignty; open only in late summer, with expensive icebreakers; a new gold rush for hydrocarbons and minerals that could raise international tensions; unpredictable effects on the ice; fragile ecosystems and indigenous communities.

EXAMPLE A balanced judgement: the benefits are real but mostly future, while the constraints are present — so the claim that they "far outweigh" them is only partly valid today. (The correction says 90% of world trade; part I of the course says 80% by volume: the figure depends on the source and the measure.)

IV.1 Geopolitical conflict in maritime zones: territorial claims

In the South China Sea, China claims almost everything inside its nine-dash line

China claims historical rights over most of the South China Sea, inside its "nine-dash line". Its claims overlap those of Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan, over the Paracel and Spratly Islands and Scarborough Shoal; in the East China Sea, China and Japan dispute the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands. Five maritime entries lead into the South China Sea and East Asia: the Taiwan Strait, the Luzon Strait, the passages through the Philippines, the Strait of Malacca and the Sunda Strait — whoever controls the sea controls the approaches to China.

EXAMPLE Even maps are contested: Vietnam banned Barbie because a map seemed to show the nine-dash line (G1, intro). On the ground, China has built and militarised artificial islands, such as Fiery Cross Reef in the Spratlys (Worksheet 11).

The stakes: trade routes, resources and military control

The South China Sea combines every stake of maritime areas: one of the world's busiest trade routes, between the Strait of Malacca and the ports of East Asia; fish; oil and gas; and military control of the approaches to China. Holding islands means claiming EEZs around them, and so their resources.

EXAMPLE The course's map: the South China Sea covers roughly 3 million km², lies on lucrative hydrocarbon deposits, is an important source of fish and houses some of the world's biggest coral reefs; more than US$5 trillion of trade passes through the region each year. (Worksheet 6 gives $3.5 trillion through the Strait of Malacca and across the South China Sea: the estimates differ according to the source and what they count — G1, II.2.) China found the 100-million-ton Huizhou 19-6 oilfield in 2025 in the undisputed part of its EEZ (G1, I.2).

The rule of law against the rule of force

International law has ruled against China, but China ignores it. Allowing it to change the situation unilaterally by force would leave the South China Sea governed by the rule of force rather than the rule of law.

EXAMPLE On 12 July 2016, the arbitral tribunal of the South China Sea case, brought by the Philippines, rejected China's nine-dash line. On 21 March 2021, about 220 Chinese fishing vessels — China's maritime militia — moored in military formation in the Philippines' EEZ in the Spratlys, about 175 nautical miles west of Palawan; the Philippines protested but could not remove them (Worksheet 11, The Diplomat, 2021).

A regional dispute that has become global

The South China Sea is no longer just a regional issue. The countries that oppose China's actions defend the freedom of navigation and the peaceful resolution of disputes in a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific", and European navies join them.

EXAMPLE The Free and Open Indo-Pacific Strategy is put forward by the Quad — Japan, the United States, Australia and India; the United Kingdom, France and Germany have taken part in joint military exercises based on it (Sakamoto Shigeki, The Diplomat, 2021).

Maritime borders can also be settled by agreement

Disputes over maritime borders are not always conflicts without end: delimiting EEZs can open the way to cooperation and to the shared exploitation of resources, even between enemies.

EXAMPLE Israel and Lebanon, two countries technically at war, reached an agreement in 2022 that ended a long dispute over their maritime border in the Mediterranean: Israel keeps full rights to develop the Karish gas field, Lebanon full rights in Qana, opening the door to offshore energy exploration. On the course's map, Lebanon's formal claim (Line 23) and its maximalist claim (Line 29) overlap Israel's line; the agreement follows Line 23, and Lebanon's Block 9, around Qana, was licensed to Eni, Total and Novatek.

IV.2 Sea power

Sea power: using the seas, protecting oneself, destroying the enemy's fleet

Sea power is the capacity to use the seas for various purposes, including protection from enemy attack and the capacity to destroy the enemy's fleet, commercial and military. Sea power also allows a state to bombard land objectives from the sea. Aircraft carriers and submarines have increased the strategic importance of sea power.

> **EXAMPLE** The US Navy alone has 11 aircraft carriers, 66 submarines, 73 destroyers and 340,000 active personnel, with a base budget of $244 billion for the Navy and Marines in 2023 (Council on Foreign Relations).

A maritime power controls its coasts and projects influence far away

A maritime power is able to control its coast and to exert influence upon both nearby and far countries (key term). A navy has “command of the sea” when it is so strong that its rivals cannot attack it directly. Overseas bases allow a navy to be present on every ocean.

> **EXAMPLE** The US Navy's forward deployed bases ring the world: Rota (Spain), Naples and Sigonella (Italy), Souda Bay (Greece), Bahrain, Djibouti, Diego Garcia, Singapore, Guam, Okinawa, Sasebo and Yokosuka (Japan), Chinhae (South Korea), Pearl Harbor and Guantanamo Bay.

A hierarchy of navies dominated by the USA, with China rising

The hierarchy of sea powers is very unequal: the United States far ahead, then Russia and China, then Japan, the United Kingdom, France and India. China's sea power is growing fast, with its navy and its artificial islands, which challenges American command of the seas of East Asia.

> **EXAMPLE** The world's largest navies by tonnage: United States 3,415,893 t; Russia 845,730; China 708,886; Japan 413,800; United Kingdom 367,850; France 319,195; India 317,725; South Korea 178,710; Italy 173,549; Taiwan 151,662. Course video: “Chinese sea power” (12 min).

Key figures

Gabriella Gricius
Researcher in Arctic politics: the Arctic shifts from cooperation to competition (2021)

Niels Clemensen
Head of Royal Arctic Line, Greenland's only shipping company

Johanna Ikävalko
Director of the Arctic Centre: “the world order will start to evolve from the Arctic”

Vittus Qujaukitsoq
Head of Greenland's fishers' and hunters' association

Donald Trump
US president who wants Greenland

Sakamoto Shigeki
Japanese professor: the South China Sea has become a global issue (2021)

Numbers

3
Arctic routes: Northeast Passage, Northwest Passage, Transpolar Sea Route

2 weeks
Time the Northwest Passage could save between Europe and Asia

50+ / 7
Russian icebreakers, of which seven are nuclear

0
Icebreakers of Denmark, in charge of Greenland's defence, since 2010

220
Chinese militia vessels in the Philippines' EEZ, March 2021

11
Aircraft carriers of the US Navy

3.4 Mt
Tonnage of the US Navy, four times Russia's

Vocabulary

NEW ROUTES

The Arctic
Polar region around the North Pole, with seasonal ice cover (key term).

Northern Sea Route
Arctic route along the Russian coast (Northeast Passage).

Northwest Passage
Arctic route through the Canadian archipelago, claimed by Canada.

Transpolar Sea Route
Future route straight across the pole.

Icebreaker
Ship that clears a way through the ice.

Sea ice
Frozen sea water, shrinking with global warming.

CONFLICT AND POWER AT SEA

Nine-dash line
China's claim over most of the South China Sea, rejected in 2016.

Arbitration
Settlement of a dispute by a tribunal (the Philippines v. China, 2016).

Maritime militia
Fishing boats used as a paramilitary force (China).

Freedom of navigation
The right of all ships to sail on the high seas and through straits.

Sea power
Capacity to use the seas, protect oneself and destroy the enemy's fleet.

Maritime power
A state able to control its coast and exert influence near and far (key term).

Command of the sea
Naval superiority so great that rivals cannot attack directly.

Power projection
Ability to send forces far away (carriers, overseas bases).